What predicts a federal candidate's small-dollar share?

FEC candidate summaries, 2016-2024. Generated 2026-11-10 by analysis/regression.py. Every number is from that run. Public data only.

Question

Among major-party House and Senate candidates with at least $50,000 in individual receipts, what predicts the unitemized (under $200 per donor per cycle) share of those individual receipts?

Sample

N = 6,101 candidate-cycles. Mean small-dollar share 20.2%. Challengers 26.3%, open seats 17.4%, incumbents 14.6%. Democrats 22.9%, Republicans 17.4%.

Main OLS (clustered by state)

Variable	Coef. (SE), pp	p
Incumbent (vs challenger)	-12.6 (0.7)	< 0.001
Open seat (vs challenger)	-8.4 (0.6)	< 0.001
Senate (vs House)	4.6 (1.1)	< 0.001
Democrat (vs Republican)	4.7 (1.1)	< 0.001
Log individual receipts	1.6 (0.3)	< 0.001

N = 6,101. R-squared = 0.153.

Plain English

Holding the other regressors fixed, incumbents' small-dollar share is -12.6 percentage points lower than challengers' (SE 0.7, p < 0.001). Democrats are 4.7 percentage points higher than Republicans (SE 1.1, p < 0.001). The fractional logit average partial effects have the same signs. This is an association, not a causal effect.

Limitations

Incumbency is not random. District partisanship and race competitiveness are missing (FEC vote share is not in this file). The $200 line is a reporting rule. State bulk files are not in this regression because their itemization rules and labels are not comparable. Full writeup: docs/regression-writeup.md.

Reproduce

```
pip install -e '.[analysis]'
python analysis/regression.py
```